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Day 13 → Essay

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Q) Doubling farmers' income is not just a necessity for farmers but a crucial driver for India's economic growth. (100 M)

Ans) Doubling farmers' income is about increasing the income of farmers through various schemes and strategies focusing on productivity, diversification, and market access. It is crucial to address agrarian distress, promote farmers' welfare and reduce poverty in rural areas. All these would eventually contribute to a more equitable and prosperous India. That is why, it is said that doubling farmers' income is not just a necessity for farmers but a crucial driver for India's economic growth.

"To Those who work in acres
not in hours"

Whether it is winter's chill or summer's heat, a farmer looks continuously to the world can eat. We all need a doctor, a lawyer, a policeman and a preacher once in our life. But everyday, three times a

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day, we need a farmer. Farmers are the backbone of Agricultural economy and agriculture is the backbone of social economy. In her budget speech, our finance minister described agriculture as the "first engine of India's development journey". To keep up the agricultural economy, it is important that well-being of farmers are prioritised. Prioritising farmers' economic health has a trickle down effect on the overall economic health of the country.

Now to understand the effect of farmers' income on India's economic growth, let us see through the long history attached to agriculture. It has always been the basis of Indian civilization, from Indus valley's cultivated plains to the terraced fields of the South Peninsula. Barley and wheat cultivation along with domestication of cattle was visible in Indus valley settlements. With the innovation of irrigation system, the settlement grew in a more planned and sophisticated way. In Vedic age, agriculture was a sustainable and organic farming system based on principles of Vedas.

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During the Mahajanapads period, agriculture flourished with advancements like Iron ploughshares and paddy transplantation. This development kept steady till pre-British era. However, during British rule, agriculture was commercialized. This led to neglect of food crops and the impoverishment of farmers. Farmers' income deteriorated with heavy land taxes, exploitative land revenue systems, lack of investment in agricultural infrastructure etc.

Even post-independence Indian farmers faced challenges leading to debt burden, income fluctuations etc. Despite this income disparities, we never had any official data on incomes of farm households until 2003. Yet this official source of data is not enough to correctly assess the farmer's income. It is important to get our statistics right, if we are serious about understanding

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And addressing agrarian distress.

Through the recap of history of Agriculture in India, we now understand that the economic health of farmers get worsened with each passing time. Prioritising profitability of industrialists and capitalists, farmers are pushed into vicious cycle of pauperization. To break this cycle, government has come forward with the strategy of doubling farmers' income. It is crucial for India's rural development. This can lead to improved infrastructure, better healthcare, and enhanced overall prosperity, directly impacting the livelihoods of millions.

The premise of this strategy (of enhancing farmers' income) clearly has double benefit. One would be the well-being of individual farmers and other would be the overall growth of India's economy. Let us elaborate each of the two benefits separately. First

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he would understand how doubling farmers income is a necessity for farmers.

"Farmers are the only indispensable people on the face of the earth."

"They are the magician who produces money from the mud."

Through increase in their income, they would be able to focus on improving crop yields using cutting-edge technologies, to shift towards high-value crops and livestock farming, to improve storage infrastructure, to increase the crop intensity and many others. All this could lead to more investment in farms and their livelihoods, ultimately resulting into a sustainable and prosperous agricultural sector. Higher income provide them with more financial security, better debt management, access to high quality education, healthcare and housing. Thus improving their standard of living.

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The benefits are multifaceted not just limited to improved living standard. Farmers can diversify their income sources through non-farm and allied activities like fish farming, livestock, handicrafts, agroprocessing, etc. Here, we can see how financial stability opens the door of varied economic activities. This would not only reduce the employment stress on agriculture but also unlocks the path of rural economic growth.

And we all know that 63% of India's population reside in rural areas. This shows the huge potential of rural economic growth translates to overall economic growth of India. With this let us understand the second benefit of doubling farmers income, that is, India's economic growth. When rural income increases, people have more money to spend leading to higher demand both locally and nationally. More demand creates more job and further boosting income sources.

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With more money coming in, need for better infrastructure like roads, electricity, communication networks etc. also increases.

This can lead to more investment and economic activity, thus creating a positive environment for entrepreneurship in rural areas. Entrepreneurial growth is one of the most crucial drivers of overall economic growth.

As we have witnessed how a thriving agriculture boosts farmer's income, it also has a multiplier effect on India's economic growth as a whole. Thus, it is said that doubling farmers' income is not just a necessity for farmers but a crucial driver for India's economic growth too. So, to realise its full potential, let us

"Strive towards a prosperous agriculture,
work towards a booming rural economy,
helping through the prosperous farming community
and thus aiming for a flourishing and thriving
Indian economy."